tmux cheat sheet

prefix **Ctrl+t** · tmux 3.6a
~/.config/tmux/tmux.conf

> **Ctrl + t**
>
> is the **prefix**. Press it, **release**, then the key. Everything marked `^t` below needs it first. Keys without that marker work directly.

SESSIONS — FROM THE SHELL

`tmux`	Start a new unnamed session
`tmux new -s work`	New session named work
`tmux new -s work -c ~/dev`	...starting in a directory
`tmux ls`	List all sessions
`tmux a`	Attach to the most recent
`tmux a -t work`	Attach to a named session
`tmux kill-session -t work`	Kill one session
`tmux kill-server`	**Kill everything** — the fix when a config change seems ignored

Your `t` shortcut: `t` alone fzf-picks a session · `t office` attaches or creates it in the right directory · unknown names resolve through zoxide.
These are shell commands — run them from a normal terminal. Inside tmux, `tmux new -s x` fails with *"sessions should be nested with care"*. See the next block for creating one from inside.

SESSIONS — FROM INSIDE

`^t` `:` `new -s api`	**Create a new session** and switch to it — the command prompt runs inside the server, so no nesting error
`^t` `:` `new -s api -c ~/dev`	...starting in a directory
`^t` `d`	**Detach** — leave it running (also closes the Claude popup)
`^t` `s`	Visual session/window tree — pick and jump
`^t` `$`	Rename this session
`^t` `(` `)`	Previous / next session
`^t` `D`	Choose a client to detach
`^t` `:`	Command prompt — any tmux command

Prefer the shell? Create detached, then switch — this works from inside:
`tmux new-session -d -s api -c ~/dev/api && tmux switch-client -t api`

WINDOWS *(TABS)*

`^t` `c`	New window, same directory
`^t` `,`	Rename window
`^t` `n` / `p`	Next / previous window
`^t` `0`...`9`	Jump to window by number
`^t` `w`	Choose window from a tree
`^t` `f`	**Find window** by name
`^t` `&`	Kill window (asks first)
`^t` `<` / `>`	Move this window left / right
`Ctrl` `⇧` `←` / `→`	Move window — no prefix needed
`^t` `.`	Move window to another index

PANES *(SPLITS)*

`^t` `|`	Split **vertical** — new pane to the right
`^t` `-`	Split **horizontal** — new pane below
`^t` `\` / `_`	Split full-width / full-height
`^t` `h` `j` `k` `l`	Move left / down / up / right
`^t` `←↓↑→`	Same, with arrows
`^t` `H` `J` `K` `L`	Resize by 5 (hold for repeat)
`^t` `z`	**Zoom** pane fullscreen — again to restore
`^t` `;`	Last pane (toggle back and forth)
`^t` `q`	Show pane numbers — press one to jump
`^t` `x`	Kill this pane (asks first)
`^t` `e`	**Kill all panes except this one**
`^t` `!`	Break pane out into its own window
`^t` `{` / `}`	Swap pane with previous / next
`^t` `Space`	Cycle to the next layout
`^t` `⌥` `1`...`5`	Preset layouts (even-h, even-v, main-h, main-v, tiled)

POPUPS — THE CUSTOM ONES

^t g	**lazygit** in an 80% popup. Close with q.
^t y	**Claude Code** in a popup — one persistent session per directory. Close with ^t d.
^t o	Open current directory in Finder

> Two different exits: lazygit runs **directly** in the popup, so q quits it. Claude runs in a **nested session**, so you **detach** with ^t d and the conversation keeps running.

COPY MODE — SCROLLING & SELECTING

^t [	**Enter copy mode** — now you can scroll
Space	Start selection
Enter	Copy selection and exit
v	Toggle **rectangle** (block) selection
/ / ?	Search down / up
n / N	Next / previous match
g / G	Top / bottom of history
H / L	Top / bottom of screen
q	Leave copy mode
^t]	Paste the buffer
^t =	Choose from all paste buffers

> **Note:** v is *rectangle-toggle* here, not begin-selection — this config uses tmux's vi defaults. Selection is Space, copy is Enter.

SAVING & RESTORING

^t Ctrl s	Save all sessions now
^t Ctrl r	**Restore saved sessions**

> Auto-save runs every **15 min**. Auto-*restore* is **off** — it could fail partway at startup and drop you out of tmux entirely. Restore by hand after starting tmux. Saves live in `~/.local/share/tmux/resurrect/`.

CONFIG & PLUGINS

^t r	Reload config
^t ?	List every binding
^t I	Install plugins (tpm)
^t U	Update plugins
^t ⌥ u	Remove unused plugins
^t t	Clock
^t ~	Show tmux messages (useful when something failed)

COMMON RECIPES

Start a project	`t kiosk` from a normal shell — attaches or creates it
New session, already in tmux	^t : then `new -s name`
Editor + terminal	`nvim`, then ^t |, then ^t h to go back
Read long output	^t z to zoom, ^t [to scroll
Quick git	^t g → do the work → q
Dev server	Own pane, not nvim's terminal — it survives closing the editor
Leave for the day	^t d — everything keeps running
Something's stuck	`tmux kill-server`, then ^t Ctrl r to restore